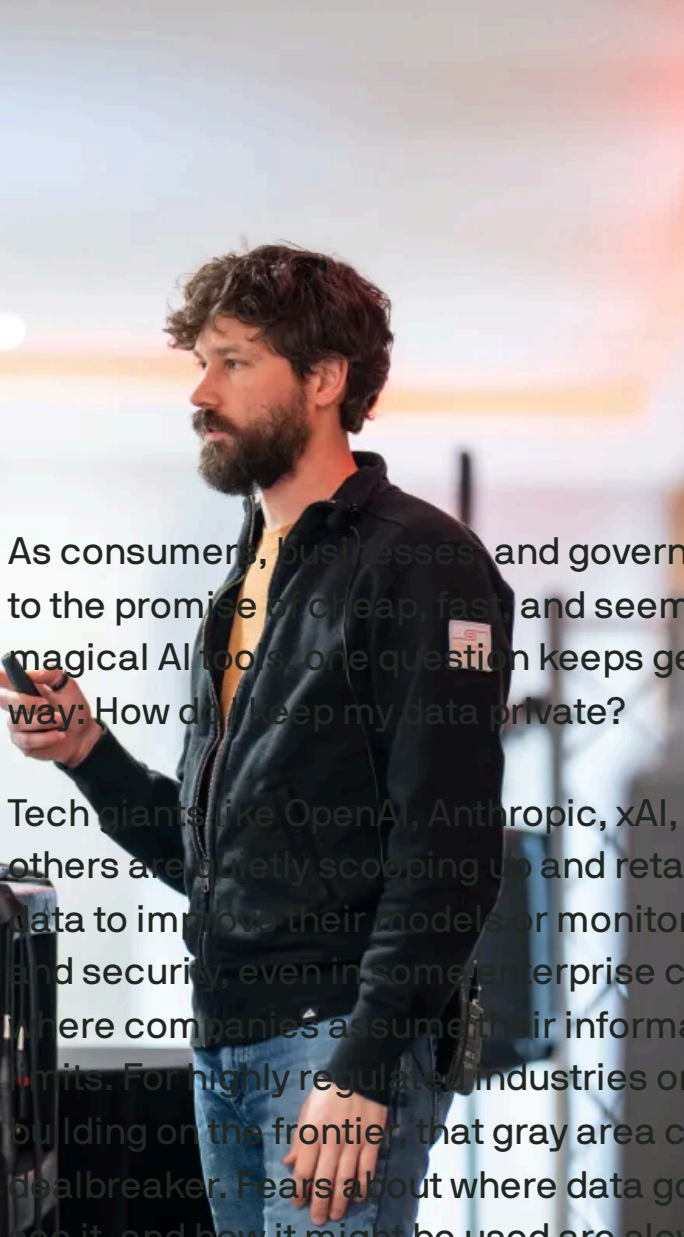


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AI



Confident Security, ‘the Signal for AI,’ comes out of stealth with \$4.2M



As consumers, businesses, and governments flock to the promise of cheap, fast, and seemingly magical AI tools, one question keeps getting in the way: How do I keep my data private?

Tech giants like OpenAI, Anthropic, xAI, Google, and others are quietly scooping up and retaining user data to improve their models or monitor for safety and security, even in some enterprise contexts where companies assume their information is off limits. For highly regulated industries or companies building on the frontier, that gray area could be a dealbreaker. Fears about where data goes, who can see it, and how it might be used are slowing AI adoption in sectors like healthcare, finance, and government.

IMAGE CREDIT: CONFIDENT SECURITY

Enter San Francisco-based startup [Confident Security](#), which aims to be “the Signal for AI.” The company’s product, CONFSEC, is an end-to-end encryption tool that wraps around foundational models, guaranteeing that prompts and metadata can’t be stored, seen, or used for AI training, even by the model provider or any third party.

“The second that you give up your data to someone else, you’ve essentially reduced your privacy,” Jonathan Mortensen, founder and CEO of Confident Security, told TechCrunch. “And our product’s goal is to remove that trade-off.”

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Confident Security came out of stealth on Thursday with \$4.2 million in seed funding from Decibel, South Park Commons, Ex Ante, and Swyx, TechCrunch has exclusively learned. The company wants to serve as an intermediary vendor between AI vendors and their customers — like hyperscalers, governments, and enterprises.

Even AI companies could see the value in offering Confident Security's tool to enterprise clients as a way to unlock that market, said Mortensen. He added that CONFSEC is also well-suited for new AI browsers hitting the market, like Perplexity's recently released [Comet](#), to give customers guarantees that their sensitive data isn't being stored on a server somewhere that the company or bad actors could access, or that their work-related prompts aren't being used to "train AI to do your job."

CONFSEC is modeled after Apple's Private Cloud Compute (PCC) architecture, which Mortensen says "is 10x better than anything out there in terms of guaranteeing that Apple cannot see your data" when it runs certain AI tasks securely in the cloud.

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Like Apple's PCC, Confident Security's system works by first anonymizing data by encrypting and routing it through services like Cloudflare or Fastly, so servers never see the original source or content. Next, it uses advanced encryption that only allows decryption under strict conditions.

"So you can say you're only allowed to decrypt this if you are not going to log the data, and you're not going to use it for training, and you're not going to let anyone see it," Mortensen said.

Finally, the software running the AI inference is publicly logged and open to review so that experts can verify its guarantees.

"Confident Security is ahead of the curve in recognizing that the future of AI depends on trust built into the infrastructure itself," Jess Leão, partner at Decibel, said in a statement. "Without solutions like this, many enterprises simply can't move forward with AI."

It's still early days for the year-old company, but Mortensen said CONFSEC has been tested, externally audited, and is production-ready. The team is in talks with banks, browsers, and search engines, among other potential clients, to add CONFSEC to their infrastructure stacks.

"You bring the AI, we bring the privacy," said Mortensen.

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AI

Proton’s new privacy-first AI assistant encrypts all chats, keeps no logs

Ivan Mehta — 5:49 AM PDT · July 23, 2025

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[iOS](#) apps, Lumo doesn't require you to have an account to use the chatbot and ask questions. You can upload files to have the chatbot answer questions about them, and if you have a [Proton Drive](#) account, you can connect it with Lumo to access files stored in the cloud. While the chatbot has access to the web, it might not find you the latest results if you use it to search.

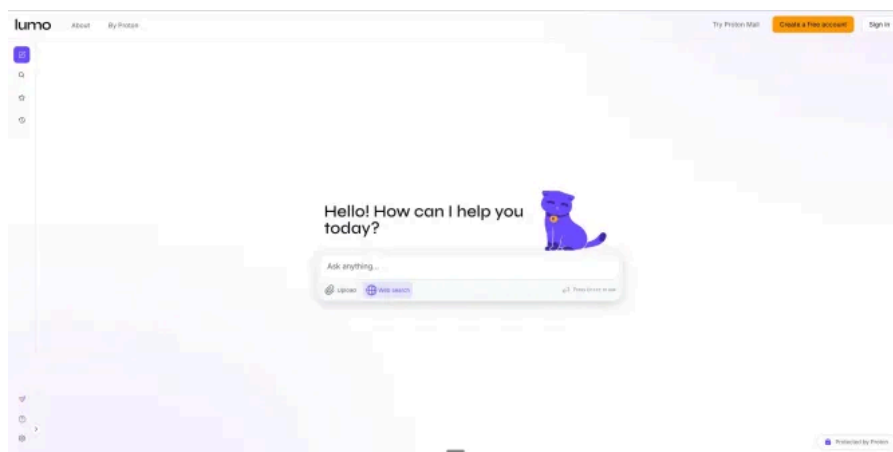


IMAGE CREDITS: SCREENSHOT BY TECHCRUNCH

Proton seems intent on making it clear that its focus is on privacy. The company says Lumo is based on open source models, and it will only depend on them for research and development going forward without utilizing user data to train its models. It also said Lumo relies on zero-access encryption, an encryption method that other Proton products also use, to let users store their conversation history, which can be decrypted on the device.

Throughout its [blog post about Lumo](#), Proton emphasized its European base, saying it gives the

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company a leg up over AI companies based in the U.S. and China when it comes to privacy.

	 Lumo by Proton	 Gemini	 Copilot	 OpenAI	 deepseek
Never uses your data to train AI	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗
Deletes all logs of your chats	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗
Can't share your data with anyone	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗
Has an ad-free business model	✓	✗	✗	✓	✗
Based in a high-privacy jurisdiction	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗
Opens source code to the public	✓	✗	✗	✗	✓
Start a chat					

IMAGE CREDITS: PROTON.ME

“Lumo is based upon open-source language models and operates from Proton’s European datacenters. This gives you much greater transparency into the way Lumo works than any other major AI assistant. Unlike Apple Intelligence and others, Lumo is not a partnership with OpenAI or other American or Chinese AI companies, and your queries are never sent to any third parties,” Proton said.

This is not Proton’s first foray into the fast-developing AI tools space: Last year, it rolled out [an AI-powered writing assistant for its Mail product](#) that also runs on the user’s device.

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BIOTECH & HEALTH



Rad AI, a startup that helps radiologists save time on report generation, raises \$50M Series B from Khosla Ventures

In 2017, Vinod Khosla [told CNBC](#) that the job “of the radiologist will be obsolete in five years.” While the founder of Khosla Ventures later revised [that timeline to as long as 15 years](#), he maintained that AI image recognition could soon diagnose disease on scans better than human doctors.

Seven years later, radiologists are still required to interpret most scans (even if AI software helps them); the more immediate challenge is the shortage of these doctors in the [United States](#) and [around the world](#).

While Khosla Ventures has backed several imaging startups, including [Vista.ai](#) and [Q Bio](#), the firm’s latest bet is on a company that makes radiologists’ workload easier by [reducing the time spent on report documentation](#), instead of trying to replace the physician with a machine.

On Tuesday, Khosla led a \$50 million Series B into [Rad AI](#), which developed a tool that can generate reports for radiologists. Other participants in the round included World Innovation Lab and returning investors ARTIS Ventures, OCV Partners, Kickstart Fund and Gradient Ventures (Google’s AI-focused fund). The financing brought the company’s total capital raised to over \$80 million.

Rad AI was founded in 2018 by Dr. Jeff Chang, who completed his medical training as a radiologist when he was 16 and later received an MBA from UCLA, and serial entrepreneur Doktor Gurson.

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Since Chang knew from his own experience as a practicing doctor that the majority of radiologists' time is spent documenting findings rather than analyzing images, the pair decided to develop a proprietary LLM trained on radiology report datasets for automating doctors' findings and impressions documentation.

While tech companies didn't widely use generative AI until OpenAI's ChatGPT burst onto the scene in 2022, Rad AI takes pride in being an early adopter of this technology. "I'm confident we're the first company in radiology to start using LLMs," Gurson, Rad AI's CEO told TechCrunch. "We started doing that work in 2018, around the same time that open AI was creating their [first] models."

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Six years later, Rad AI's products are used by about a third of U.S. health systems and nine of the 10 largest radiology groups in the country, Gurson said.

The fresh capital will be used to build a team that deploys Rad AI’s latest product: a standalone radiology reporting solution.

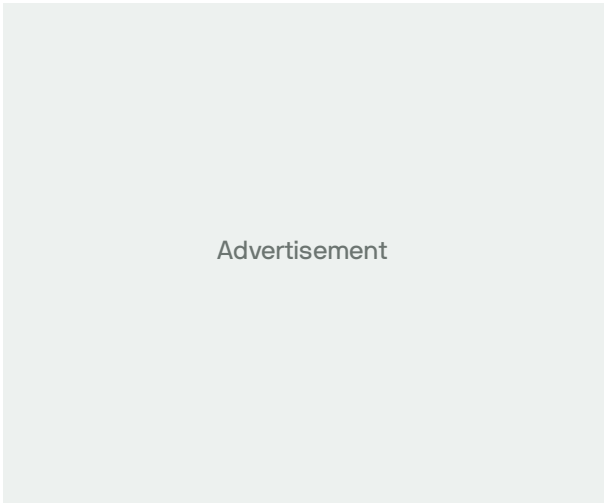
“We have a lot of interest, but there’s only so much we can deploy at once,” Gurson said, adding that Rad AI is hiring people who can install and maintain the software.

Some incumbents have been trying to add GenAI functionality to their radiology reporting software over the past 18 months, but Rad AI doesn’t consider these companies to be true competitors yet.

“At this point, probably 99% to 100% of the market uses our products,” he said. “If it’s any indication, we’ve not lost a single customer since we started.”

Topics: [Biotech & Health](#) [Exclusive](#) [Khosla Ventures](#)

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